

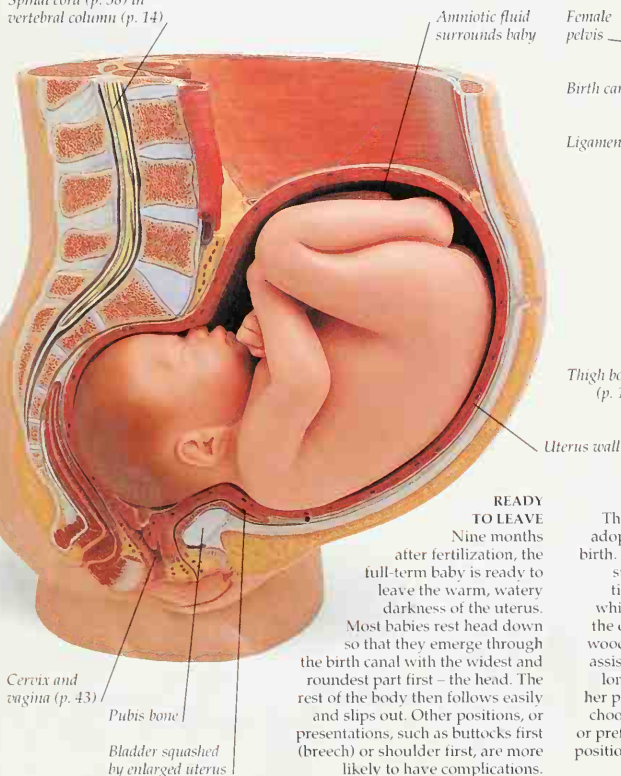
Birth and baby



MOTHER AND HER NEWBORN CHILD

The minutes and hours soon after birth are very important for mother and new baby. They quickly learn to recognize each other, particularly by scent, a sense (pp. 56-57) that is deeply rooted in the emotional parts of the brain (p. 61). The human mother-baby bond is extremely powerful, as it is even in wild animals.

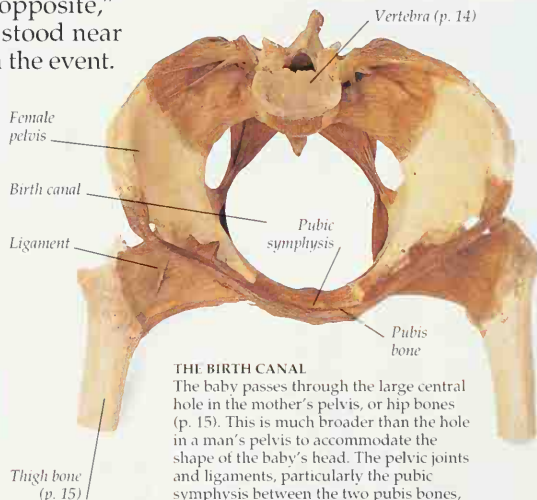
Spinal cord (p. 58) in vertebral column (p. 14)



READY TO LEAVE

Nine months after fertilization, the full-term baby is ready to leave the warm, watery darkness of the uterus. Most babies rest head down so that they emerge through the birth canal with the widest and roundest part first – the head. The rest of the body then follows easily and slips out. Other positions, or presentations, such as buttocks first (breech) or shoulder first, are more likely to have complications.

Sometimes the labor is slow, or the baby becomes stuck. Methods used to “help” the birth have ranged from the ineffectual to the barbaric. The surgical Caesarean delivery is named after Roman Emperor Julius Caesar (100-44 BC), supposedly born this way. In the past, it was usually carried out only if the mother died. Only this century have mother and baby had a reasonable chance. The medical specialty of childbirth is obstetrics, from the Latin *obstare*. This means to “stand opposite,” referring to the midwife who stood near the mother to help her through the event.



THE BIRTH CANAL

The baby passes through the large central hole in the mother's pelvis, or hip bones (p. 15). This is much broader than the hole in a man's pelvis to accommodate the shape of the baby's head. The pelvic joints and ligaments, particularly the pubic symphysis between the two pubis bones, stretch slightly to make the hole larger.

POSITION FOR BIRTH

Throughout the ages mothers have adopted various positions for giving birth. The obstetrical chair, or birthing stool, has been used since ancient times to support the mother while allowing gravity the delivery. This 16th-century woodcut shows a mother being assisted by a midwife, with the long, loose dress maintaining her privacy. Some mothers may choose to lie back with legs up, or prefer to crouch in a squatting position, or even give birth while floating in a pool of water.

